



Player Details

Name: Andrei Rațiu

Nationality: Romania

Position: RB

Foot: Right

Team: Rayo Vallecano

Salary: €9,615/week

Birth Date: 20/06/1998 (26)

Int'l Apps: 29

Height: 6ft/1.83cm

Weight: 75kg

Market Value: €12m

Contract Expiration: June, 2028

Andrei Rațiu has established himself as one of the best right-backs in La Liga in the 2024-25 season, and is above average in many key metrics among Europe’s top five leagues. Now in his second season at Rayo Vallecano, he’s started the past two games as an right attacking forward, a symbol of his attacking intent as a player. He signed from La Liga 2 side Huesca, played one season in the Eredivisie for ADO Den Haag before that, and is a product of Villarreal’s academy. He’s also a fixture at right-back for his country, and represented Romania at the 2024 European Championships, and in every game since.

Physically: Above average pace, enough to beat opposing left-backs and left-midfielders down the right flank — his 2.4 successful take-ons per 90 minutes are in the 99th percentile of all full-backs in Europe’s top five leagues, though his success rate (53%) could improve. Solid athletic build, but at 1.83m/6ft, I’d expect him to be better in aerial duels — has a below average Aerial Elo Rating Optimization at both ends of the pitch. While I wasn’t able to find his number of sprints, accelerations, high-intensity distance covered, sprinting distance, and total sprints per 90 using available open data, his endurance and ability to consistently play 90 minutes every week stands out. His 2,718 total domestic league minutes rank 10th most among 138 defenders in La Liga, and 63rd among 704 defenders from the top five European leagues. Missed three games this season due to a muscle injury, his only absence due to injury in his career, apart from when he contracted Covid in 2021.

Technically: Comfortable with ball at his feet when dribbling — 4.3 progressive carries per 90 minutes, for an average of 117yds/106m per game, both metrics almost double the average for full-backs in Europe — and has an 81% overall pass accuracy. Less comfortable making long passes over 30 yards, where his pass accuracy drops to 51%. While his 2.4 crosses per 90 are well above average, his 14% accuracy on those crosses raises questions of whether this could be due to his team’s lack of forward quality in the penalty area. Rayo are among the worst in front of goal this season, scoring just 1.08 goals per game in La Liga, and in the bottom 20% of the league in many other key attacking metrics. They don’t regularly play with a recognized striker, instead using attacking midfielders and wide forwards as false No.9s.

Tactically: Has shown good tactical awareness on many occassions this season. His man-marking of Vinícius Júnior in approximately 140 minutes across the two fixtures was impressive. He limited the Real Madrid forward to just 12 successful touches in the final third, often pressuring him all the way to the halfway line. Rațiu has played the past two games as an attacking right winger, and shows good awareness and willingness to run back to defend. Took only one shot in those two games as a right attacking midfielder, so might need to allow for an adjustment period depending on the offensive system he plays in — more coverage needed to accurately assess whether he’s able to morph himself into a successful forward tactically. Has played at a high level with Romania at European Championships. He’s fluent in Spanish and I believe in English as well.

Attacking: Shows attacking intent majority of time with the ball. Has contributed 2 goals and 3 assists in La Liga this season, and his expected goal involvements is 7. Creates almost 3 shots per 90 minutes, almost double that of defenders in La Liga and Europe. Only 25% shots have been on target, mostly due to the difficulty of the shots he takes — 0.06xG per shot. Needs to improve touch with left foot to open upmore central areas of the pitch.

Defending: Majority of key defensive metrics — tackles, interceptions, blocks — rank in and around average for full-backs across top five European leagues. However, when compared to the rest of his team, Rațiu leads in the number of total tackles, dribblers tackled, tackles + interceptions, and is second in blocks. Has made just two errors leading to an opposition shot all season. Has been a part of a very successful defense this season, with 9 clean sheets and 16 games with only one goal conceded.

Conclusion: Breakout season for Rayo, arguably their best player. Will likely garner a lot of attention from many mid-level clubs around Europe this summer. Has similar key metrics to the likes of Atlético Madrid’s Marcos Llorente, Borussia Dortmund’s Julian Ryerson and Bayern Munich’s Konrad Laimer, of whom have an average market value of €24 million. I believe at his age (27 at the start of next season) and his level of experience, he has the quality to succeed at a top club competing in the Europa League. He has a reported buyout clause of €25m, though I think €16m-€20m should be enough to secure his services this summer due to Rayo’s financial situation.

Games Watched: Osasuna (H), September 16, 2024; Leganés (A), January 31st 2025; Valladolid (H), February 7 2025; Sevilla (H), March 1st 2025; Real Madrid (A), March 9th 2025; Las Palmas (A), May 9, 2025; Real Betis (H), May 15th 2025.